THE TWO-WHEELER BUYER PLAYBOOK

INDIA FESTIVE 2026 EDITION

Bikes, scooters and electric two-wheelers - the complete money system for buying in the Dhanteras-to-Diwali window, verified against the 2026 rules.

GST 2.0 rates | PM E-DRIVE | the 5-year insurance rule | road tax by state | the negotiation script | the delivery checklist

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How to use this playbook

This is a buying system, not a brochure. It is written for the person who is about to spend Rs.70,000 to Rs.2,00,000 on a two-wheeler in India's 2026 festive season and wants to pay the right price, avoid the showroom traps, and ride away with the right machine for the next five years.

Work through it in order the first time. Part 1 sets the timing and the market. Part 2 helps you decide what to buy. Part 3 is the money - on-road price, tax, offers and loans. Part 4 is insurance. Part 5 is the deal and the negotiation. Part 6 is delivery, registration and the first month. Part 7 covers electric two-wheelers. Part 8 is life after you buy. The last pages are a one-page checklist, an FAQ and the sources.

Verify before you sign

Prices, road tax rates, insurance premiums and scheme rules change by state and by month. Every number here is the most recent official figure we could verify as of mid-October 2026, but treat it as your starting point. Before you pay, ask the dealer for the full on-road breakup in writing and check your state transport department's current rate. Nothing here is financial advice.

What is inside

- **Part 1 - The moment.** Why 2026 is different, the festive calendar, what India is buying, and five festive myths.
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- **Part 8 - Ownership.** Running costs, resale, the 15-year rule and the fines every rider should know.
- **Part 9 - Reference.** Ten questions for the dealer, invoice reading, warranty, the glossary and a key-numbers card.
- **Part 10 - Going deeper.** Variant choice, E20 fuel, a worked case study, the complaint ladder, renewals and a comparison worksheet.
- **Part 11 - Details.** Reading a spec sheet, comfort, dealer red flags, a six-week planner, loan questions and family buying.
- **Finish.** The one-page festive checklist, the FAQ, and the sources.

Part 1 - The moment you are buying into

1. The 2026 festive window is the strongest buyer's market in years

Three things changed the maths for two-wheeler buyers in 2026, and all three work in your favour this festive season.

First, prices came down. The GST Council's September 2025 reform, which took effect on 22 September 2025, cut the tax on almost every two-wheeler on Indian roads from 28% to 18%. Every motorcycle and scooter with an engine up to 350cc - about 98% of the market - is cheaper than it was in 2024. Only premium machines above 350cc went up, to a 40% slab.

Second, the electric subsidy survived. Under the PM E-DRIVE scheme, an eligible electric two-wheeler still attracts an incentive of Rs.2,500 per kWh of battery capacity, capped at Rs.5,000 per vehicle. The government extended this to 31 March 2028 in a notification dated 10 August 2026. Many free guides online still say the subsidy ended on 31 July 2026 - it did not. It was extended, and the eligible vehicle count was raised from 24.79 lakh to 45.79 lakh units.

Third, the calendar is generous. Diwali falls on 8 November 2026 and Dhanteras on 6 November 2026, both later than usual, which gives you nearly a month from today to compare dealers calmly instead of grabbing whatever is left on the eve of the festival.

What this means for you

You are shopping in a season where the tax has already been cut, the EV subsidy has been renewed, and demand is at a record high. Your job is not to chase a discount. It is to get the correct on-road price, the right insurance, and the right machine - because the discount is worth a few thousand rupees, and the wrong decision is worth lakhs over five years.

2. Your festive calendar: the dates that matter

The festive season is not one day. It is a rolling window from Navratri to Diwali, and the deals, the crowds and the delivery times move with it. Here is the 2026 calendar for a two-wheeler buyer.

Date (2026)	What it is	What it means for a buyer
11-19 October	Navratri	Season opens. Dealers begin festive schemes. Best stock and colour choice.
20 October	Dussehra (Vijayadashami)	A traditional buying day with its own muhurat. Good stock, moderate crowd.
6 November	Dhanteras	The single biggest vehicle-buying day of the year. Peak crowd, waitlists, fastest-selling colours gone.
8 November	Diwali	Festival of lights. Many buy on or just before this day.
25, 26, 29 November	Later muhurat days	Quieter showrooms, often better negotiation, but festive schemes may have lapsed.

On Dhanteras and the days around Diwali, the panchang gives specific windows for a vehicle purchase - for example, on Dhanteras, 6 November, the morning window runs from about 10:32 AM. The exact time depends on your city and tradition, so check your local panchang or ask your family priest. The practical point is this: the muhurat fixes when you take delivery, not when you negotiate. Do the research and the deal in the quiet weeks, then time the delivery to your muhurat.

Book early, take delivery late

Popular colours and variants of best-sellers run out in the final week before Dhanteras. Book in late October when stock is full and you can still walk away from a bad deal, and schedule delivery for your chosen muhurat day. A booking is not a purchase - keep your deposit refundable until the final price is agreed in writing.

3. What India is actually buying in 2026

You are joining the largest vehicle market in the country. Knowing what everyone else buys tells you which models will hold value, which have the widest service network, and which to avoid for parts availability.

In FY 2025-26 (April 2025 to March 2026), India registered 2,21,64,883 two-wheelers, up 13.1% on the previous year and above the pre-Covid peak. The calendar year 2026 is running even hotter: 1,67,70,655 units to the end of September, up 22.0%. Two-wheelers are about 70% of all vehicles registered in India.

Rank	Manufacturer (FY 2025-26)	Registrations
1	Hero MotoCorp	61,89,682
2	Honda 2W (HMSI)	56,02,813
3	TVS Motor	42,51,080
4	Bajaj Auto	28,72,195
5	Suzuki 2W	12,00,162
6	Royal Enfield	11,51,368

The best-selling models tell the same story of value and trust. In FY26 the Hero Splendor sold 35,41,628 units, the Honda Activa 28,45,052, the TVS Jupiter 14,63,328 and the Suzuki Access 125 8,12,920. A model near the top of these lists is easy to service anywhere, holds resale value, and rarely leaves you waiting weeks for a spare part.

Electric two-wheelers are now a real segment, not a novelty: 14 lakh units in FY26, about 6.5% of the market. The leaders are TVS (iQube, 3,67,501), Bajaj (Chetak, 3,02,674), Ather (2,38,461) and Hero (Vida). The once-dominant Ola Electric fell to 1,64,215 units. If you buy electric, buying from a company with a physical service network is now the safer choice.

4. Five myths about the festive season

Each of these is widely believed and each can cost you money.

Myth	Reality
You must buy insurance from the dealer	False. Third-party cover is mandatory, but you can buy the policy yourself and show it. Only the own-damage premium is worth comparing.
The EV subsidy has ended	False. The PM E-DRIVE e-two-wheeler incentive runs to 31 March 2028, at Rs.2,500 per kWh capped at Rs.5,000.
Dhanteras always gives the best price	Often the opposite. It is the most crowded day with the thinnest stock and the least room to negotiate.
A seven-year loan makes the bike affordable	It lowers the EMI and raises the total interest. You pay far more over the loan.
Handling and logistics charges are compulsory	They are not statutory. Ask for an itemised invoice and refuse charges with no lawful basis.

Keep these five in mind. They are the difference between a festive bargain and a festive mistake.

Part 2 - Deciding what to buy

5. Start with the monthly number, not the sticker price

Most buyers shop by ex-showroom price and then discover the real cost afterwards. Flip that. Work out what you can comfortably spend every month, and let that decide the segment.

Your true monthly cost of ownership has four parts, not one: the loan EMI, the fuel or charging bill, insurance amortised over the year, and servicing. A Rs.75,000 scooter on a 3-year loan can cost less per month than a Rs.1,50,000 motorcycle you paid cash for, or more, depending on mileage and fuel. Write down all four before you walk into a showroom.

A safe rule for most households: keep the total monthly cost of the two-wheeler under about 12-15% of take-home income. If a bike's EMI plus fuel would push you past that, the bike is too expensive, whatever the discount on the sticker.

Here is a simple worksheet. Fill it in for the two or three models on your shortlist before you visit any showroom.

Monthly cost line	How to work it out	Your figure
Loan EMI	From the EMI table in section 17	
Fuel or charging	Monthly km / mileage x fuel price	
Insurance	Annual premium / 12	
Servicing	Budget about Rs.200-400 a month for a commuter	
Total	Add the four lines	
As % of take-home pay	Total / monthly take-home x 100	

6. Bike, scooter or electric: the decision in five questions

Answer these honestly. They resolve the choice faster than any spec sheet.

1. **How far do you ride each day?** Under 25 km, a 100-110cc commuter or a scooter is enough. 25-60 km, look at 125cc. Over 60 km or on highways, look at 150cc and above.
2. **Do you carry a pillion or luggage often?** Family use, school runs and market trips point to a scooter or a comfortable 125cc commuter, not a sporty street bike.
3. **Do you have a private, secure place to charge?** If yes, an electric scooter can be very cheap to run. If no, stay with petrol.
4. **How important is the lowest possible running cost?** Petrol commuters do 55-70 kmpl; an electric scooter costs a fraction per kilometre if you charge at home.
5. **Is there a service centre near you?** For any brand, and especially for electric, a workshop within reach matters more than a spec advantage.

If you answered 'short city rides, family use, no charging point', the answer is almost always a 110cc petrol scooter or a 100-110cc commuter motorcycle. If you answered 'long rides, want performance', it is a 150cc-plus motorcycle. If you answered 'short rides, home charging, lowest running cost', it is an electric scooter from an established brand.

7. Petrol vs electric: the five-year ownership math

Electric scooters are cheaper per kilometre but cost more up front. The only honest comparison is total cost over the years you will keep the vehicle. Here is the method, with an illustrative example.

Take a petrol scooter at about Rs.1.00 lakh on-road and an electric scooter at about Rs.1.15 lakh on-road after subsidy. The petrol one returns roughly 50 kmpl. Petrol at about Rs.103 a litre works out to about Rs.2.05 per kilometre. The electric one uses roughly 30 Wh per km; home electricity at about Rs.6 a unit costs about Rs.0.18 per kilometre. Over 1,000 km a month, that is about Rs.2,050 for petrol against about Rs.180 for electric - a saving of nearly Rs.1,870 a month, or roughly Rs.1.12 lakh over five years.

That fuel saving usually repays the EV's higher purchase price within three to four years of typical use. But two conditions decide everything: you must be able to charge at home, and you must ride enough kilometres for the saving to matter. Ride 300 km a month and park on the street, and petrol wins. Ride 800-1,000 km a month with a home socket, and the electric scooter is clearly cheaper.

Monthly distance	Petrol scooter (about)	Electric scooter (about)	EV saves
300 km	Rs.615	Rs.54	Rs.561
600 km	Rs.1,230	Rs.108	Rs.1,122
1,000 km	Rs.2,050	Rs.180	Rs.1,870
1,500 km	Rs.3,075	Rs.270	Rs.2,805

The break-even question

Ask yourself one number: how many kilometres will you ride in a month? Under about 500 km, or without home charging, buy petrol. Over about 700 km with home charging, the electric scooter's running cost usually wins within the loan period. Everything else - brand, battery warranty, service reach - is the tie-breaker.

8. The segment map: what each class is for

Use this to shortlist two or three models before you visit any showroom. Prices are indicative ex-showroom for 2026 and move by city and variant - verify with your dealer.

Class	Typical use	Indicative ex-showroom
100-110cc commuter	Lowest running cost, short daily rides, first bike	Rs.65,000 - Rs.80,000
110-125cc scooter	Family use, city commuting, easy to ride	Rs.74,000 - Rs.1,00,000
125cc motorcycle	City plus occasional highway, better features	Rs.85,000 - Rs.1,10,000
150-160cc motorcycle	Performance, longer rides, highway use	Rs.1,20,000 - Rs.1,55,000
Premium 350cc+	Style, touring, weekend riding	Rs.1,50,000 and above
Electric scooter	City commuting with home charging, lowest per-km cost	Rs.80,000 - Rs.1,50,000

Within each class, shortlist by what you can actually service. Hero, Honda, TVS, Bajaj and Suzuki have the widest networks in India, including small towns. Premium brands and newer electric makers have thinner networks - check the nearest service centre distance before you fall in love with a model.

9. New or used: when a second-hand two-wheeler makes sense

The festive season pushes new-vehicle prices down, but a well-chosen used two-wheeler can still cost 30-40% less than a new one. It is a real option for a first bike or a second vehicle for the family.

A used two-wheeler makes sense when your budget is tight, you will not keep it more than a few years, or you want a bigger bike than you could buy new. It makes less sense if you want the warranty, the EV subsidy, or the peace of mind of a zero-kilometre machine.

If you buy used, check these before you pay:

- **Registration certificate** in the seller's name, and no pending loan or hypothecation on it.
- **Insurance** that is in force, and a clean claim history where possible.
- **Service records** - a stamped history is the best proof of care.
- **Chassis and engine numbers** matching the RC, and an HSRP fitted.
- **No pending challans** against the vehicle number.
- **A mechanic's inspection** of the engine, frame and electricals before you pay.
- **An RC transfer** at the RTO in your name - never ride away with the RC still in the seller's name.

For an electric used scooter, the battery is the whole question. Ask for the State-of-Health report, confirm the battery warranty is transferable, and check whether the pack is still under warranty. A used EV with a near-expired battery warranty is a trap.

Part 3 - The money: on-road price, tax, offers, loans

10. Anatomy of the on-road price

The ex-showroom price is a marketing number. What you pay is the on-road price, and it has five or six parts. Learn them, because this is where dealers earn their margin and where you save the most.

Component	What it is	Rough size on a Rs.1 lakh bike
Ex-showroom price	Vehicle + GST, before state levies	About Rs.1,00,000 (varies)
Road tax (RTO)	One-time state tax, by engine and price	Rs.6,000 - Rs.13,000
Registration & plates	RTO fee, HSRP, smart card, postal	Rs.700 - Rs.1,500
Insurance	5-year third-party + 1-year own damage	Rs.6,000 - Rs.12,000
Accessories / add-ons	Optional. Negotiable. Often overpriced	Rs.0 - Rs.8,000
Extended warranty	Optional, dealer-sold	Rs.1,000 - Rs.3,000

Always ask for this breakup in writing before you discuss any discount. A dealer who will not put the on-road price on paper is telling you something. Compare the on-road figure, never the ex-showroom figure, across dealers and cities.

A worked example makes the point. Say a scooter has an ex-showroom price of Rs.90,000 in Delhi. Road tax at the applicable slab might be about Rs.5,400, registration and HSRP about Rs.1,000, and a comprehensive first-year insurance with five-year third-party about Rs.8,000. The on-road price is then roughly Rs.1,04,400 - about Rs.14,400 more than the number on the showroom board. That gap is the whole game.

11. GST 2.0: what changed and what it means at the counter

On 22 September 2025, India's biggest indirect-tax reform in years took effect. For two-wheeler buyers the change is simple and large.

Vehicle	GST before	GST now
Motorcycles and scooters up to 350cc	28%	18%
Motorcycles above 350cc	28%	40%
Electric two-wheelers	5%	5% (unchanged)

The practical effect: a mass-market bike that was Rs.1 lakh is now meaningfully cheaper, and almost the entire market sits in the 18% bracket. If a dealer shows you a 'festive price drop' measured against an old 2024 price, check whether it is just the tax cut being dressed up as a discount. Ask for the current on-road quote, not a comparison with last year.

12. Road tax, state by state

Road tax is a one-time state levy and it varies more than any other line on your bill - from about 2% of the vehicle price in parts of Delhi to 18% in Karnataka. It is charged on the ex-showroom price and is unavoidable. Electric two-wheelers get a big concession in many states.

State / UT	Typical petrol 2W road tax	Electric 2W road tax
Delhi	2% to 8% (by price slab)	Exempt
Uttar Pradesh	7% to 9%	Exempt (to Oct 2027)
Maharashtra	10% to 12% (by engine size)	Exempt
Karnataka	10% to 18% (by price)	Exempt
Tamil Nadu	8% to 11%	Reduced (about 50%)
Telangana	About 9%	Exempt
Gujarat	About 6%	Reduced (policy renewed yearly)
Madhya Pradesh	8% to 10%	Exemption lapsed March 2026 - check
Kerala	About 8% + cess	Reduced
Haryana	4% to 8%	Capped quota - check
Punjab / West Bengal	About 7%	Partial
Bihar	7% to 9%	Exempt
Rajasthan	5% to 8%	Exempt

Two warnings. First, these are indicative and change in state budgets and via notifications - always confirm your state's current rate. Second, EV road-tax exemptions are time-limited and are starting to be phased out as EV sales grow. If your state still exempts electric two-wheelers, buying this year locks in that saving before the policy changes.

13. The charges you should refuse

Beyond the vehicle price, road tax, registration fee and insurance, some dealers add charges that have no lawful basis. Knowing them is worth thousands of rupees.

Charge	What it is	What to do
Handling / logistics fee	A lump-sum add-on for stockyard and transit costs	Ask for the lawful basis. Disclosed add-ons can be refunded; refuse the undisclosed kind.
Registration service fee	An extra fee for doing the registration work	Transport departments treat a separate fee for registration work, beyond notified fees, as impermissible.
Delivery / documentation fee	A charge for handing over the vehicle	Not statutory. Ask for it to be itemised or removed.
Accessories package	A pre-bundled set of extras	Optional. Buy only what you want, priced individually.

Two rules protect you here. First, under the Consumer Protection (General) Rules, 2020, every invoice must show the total price in a single figure along with a breakup of all compulsory and voluntary charges. A dealer who hides a charge in a lump sum is breaking a written central rule. Second, in 2026 Telangana ordered a statewide crackdown on dealers collecting unauthorised handling, logistics, delivery and documentation fees, with refunds to buyers and trade-certificate action on the table. Delhi dealers have given undertakings not to charge handling or service charges. If a dealer insists on a charge with no statutory basis, ask for it in writing and take it to your RTO.

One more thing to insist on: a valid Temporary Registration certificate, issued through the Vahan portal, if the bike is delivered before permanent registration. Section 43 of the Motor Vehicles Act requires it, and some dealers skip it. Ask for the TR certificate and a receipt for every rupee you pay.

14. The festive offer, decoded

Festive 'offers' are a mix of real savings and marketing. Value each one in rupees before you let it sway you.

Offer	What it really is	How to value it
Cash discount	A genuine cut to the price	Real. Take it, and get it in writing.
Exchange bonus	Money for your old two-wheeler	Real only if the valuation is fair - get a second quote.
Free insurance	They pay the first-year premium	Real, but check it is comprehensive, not third-party only.
Free accessories	Helmet, cover, seat cover, guards	Worth Rs.1,000-3,000. Never a reason to buy.
Low or zero down payment	A longer, costlier loan	Usually a trap. It raises total interest.
Extended warranty	Extra years of cover	Useful on electric; check what it excludes.

The one rule for festive offers

Discounts on two-wheelers in the festive season are typically Rs.2,000 to Rs.5,000, sometimes with insurance or accessories bundled. Treat them as a tie-breaker between two models you already like, never as a reason to buy. A 0% processing fee or a shorter loan tenure matters more than a free helmet, and a Rs.5,000 discount on a bad deal is still a bad deal.

15. Financing: rates, tenures and the zero-down trap

If you borrow, the interest rate decides how much the bike really costs. Rates vary widely - from under 9% at some banks to over 20% at finance companies - so the lender you choose can change your total cost by tens of thousands of rupees.

Context for 2026: the RBI raised the repo rate by 25 basis points to 5.50% on 7 October 2026 and signalled that cuts are off the table for now. Loan rates are more likely to rise than fall in the coming months, which is one more reason to fix your rate and tenure carefully rather than wait.

Lender type	Typical rate (p.a.)	Notes
Public sector banks	About 8.5% to 10.6%	Lowest rates; need salary account and good credit
Private banks	About 9.5% to 15%	Faster approval; watch processing fees
NBFC / finance co.	About 12% to 24%	Easiest approval, highest cost; dealer-favoured

A few verified specifics for 2026: State Bank of India's two-wheeler loan runs from 11.70% to 15.70%, with a 0.50% concession for electric two-wheelers. Bank of India's floating rate is about 10.50%. Canara Bank runs 10.10% to 15.75% and is waiving its processing fee entirely from 1 October to 31 December 2026 - a real festive saving worth asking about. Maximum tenure is usually 60 months.

Three traps to avoid. The zero-down-payment offer is almost always a longer loan at a higher rate - you pay for the convenience in interest. A long tenure makes the EMI look small but adds years of interest. And dealer-arranged finance is often the most expensive option; get a rate from your own bank first and use it as a bargaining point.

16. Two-wheeler loans: documents and eligibility

A two-wheeler loan is one of the easiest retail loans to get, but a little preparation speeds up approval and can get you a better rate.

- **Identity and address proof:** Aadhaar, PAN, voter ID or passport, plus a recent utility bill or rent agreement.
- **Income proof:** Three months of salary slips or six months of bank statements for salaried buyers; two years of ITR and bank statements for the self-employed.
- **Photographs** and a filled application form, plus the dealer's proforma invoice.
- **Credit score:** A CIBIL score of 700 or above gets you the best rates. Check your score before you apply - a hard enquiry on a weak file can hurt.
- **Co-applicant:** Adding a co-applicant with income can raise your eligibility and lower your rate.
- **Processing fee:** Typically 0.25% to 4% of the loan. Some banks waive it in the festive quarter - ask.
- **Prepayment:** Several public banks now charge no prepayment penalty on two-wheeler loans. If you plan to repay early, confirm this in writing.

17. How much two-wheeler you can actually afford

Run this before you choose a model, not after. The EMI is only one part of the monthly cost.

Loan amount	36-month EMI @ 11%	48-month EMI @ 11%	60-month EMI @ 11%
Rs.50,000	About Rs.1,640	About Rs.1,295	About Rs.1,087
Rs.75,000	About Rs.2,460	About Rs.1,942	About Rs.1,631

Loan amount	36-month EMI @ 11%	48-month EMI @ 11%	60-month EMI @ 11%
Rs.1,00,000	About Rs.3,280	About Rs.2,590	About Rs.2,175
Rs.1,25,000	About Rs.4,100	About Rs.3,237	About Rs.2,718

Add fuel and servicing to the EMI. A Rs.1,00,000 loan over five years is about Rs.2,175 a month, but the same bike ridden 1,000 km a month adds about Rs.2,000 of petrol - so your true monthly cost is over Rs.4,000. If that is more than 12-15% of your take-home pay, step down a segment. A well-chosen Rs.80,000 bike you can run comfortably beats a Rs.1,50,000 bike that strains every month.

The affordability test

Total monthly cost (EMI + fuel + insurance + servicing) should be under 12-15% of your take-home income. If it is over, choose a smaller bike, a larger down payment, or a cheaper segment - in that order. Never solve an affordability problem with a longer tenure; that only makes the interest bigger.

18. The five-year ownership bill

The purchase price is the smallest part of what a two-wheeler costs you. Put the whole five years on one page before you commit.

Cost over 5 years	Rs.80,000 commuter	Rs.1,00,000 scooter	Rs.1,20,000 electric
Purchase (on-road)	Rs.90,000	Rs.1,15,000	Rs.1,30,000
Fuel / charging	Rs.90,000	Rs.1,20,000	Rs.11,000
Insurance (5 yrs)	Rs.18,000	Rs.20,000	Rs.22,000
Servicing & repairs	Rs.20,000	Rs.22,000	Rs.12,000
Minus resale value	Rs.35,000	Rs.45,000	Rs.35,000
Net five-year cost	About Rs.1,83,000	About Rs.2,32,000	About Rs.1,40,000

The table is illustrative and assumes 1,000 km a month, but the pattern is real: over five years the electric scooter's cheaper running cost can overtake its higher sticker price. The lesson is not 'buy electric'. It is that fuel and servicing, not the showroom price, decide what the vehicle really costs - so buy on total cost, not on the EMI alone.

Part 4 - Insurance without overpaying

19. The five-year third-party rule, explained

Every new two-wheeler sold in India must carry a five-year third-party insurance policy at the point of purchase. This is not the dealer's idea - it comes from a Supreme Court order and an IRDAI circular, effective from 1 September 2018, after regulators found that a majority of two-wheelers on the road were uninsured.

Third-party cover pays for injury, death or property damage you cause to someone else. It does not cover your own bike. Because it is mandatory for five years, the premium is collected up front, which is why a new bike's first insurance bill looks large. The premium is fixed by IRDAI and is identical at every insurer for a given engine capacity - so there is no point shopping around for a cheaper third-party premium. Where insurers compete is on the own-damage cover.

Note what happened to the long-term package: IRDAI withdrew the combined five-year third-party-plus-own-damage package on 1 August 2020. So today you get a bundled cover - five years

of third-party plus one year of own damage - and you renew the own-damage part annually after that.

20. What insurance really costs: the IRDAI rate card

Third-party premiums are set by engine capacity. These are the current slabs; they are the same at every insurer.

Engine capacity	1-year third-party	5-year third-party (new bike)
Up to 75cc	Rs.538	Rs.2,901
75cc to 150cc	Rs.714	Rs.3,851
150cc to 350cc	Rs.1,366	Rs.7,365
Above 350cc	Rs.2,804	Rs.15,117

Most commuter bikes and scooters sit in the 75-150cc band, so their five-year third-party premium is about Rs.3,851. The own-damage premium is extra and set by each insurer based on the bike's value (IDV), your city and your record. A comprehensive policy on a Rs.1 lakh bike typically adds a few thousand rupees for the first year.

Why the 5-year policy is good for you

Paying five years of third-party premium up front locks in today's rate. IRDAI revises third-party rates periodically, and they have been rising. Once you have paid the five-year premium, later hikes do not touch you until you renew. On a mid-segment bike, that is real protection against premium inflation.

21. Choosing your own-damage cover and add-ons

Third-party cover is fixed and mandatory. Own-damage cover is where you decide how much protection you want for your own bike, and where insurers compete.

- **Comprehensive cover** is third-party plus own damage. Buy it. Third-party alone leaves you paying for your own repairs and theft.
- **IDV** is the insured value of your bike. A higher IDV means a higher premium but a better payout if the bike is stolen or written off. Do not let a dealer cut the IDV to shrink the quote.
- **Zero-depreciation add-on** pays the full cost of replaced parts without deducting for age. Worth it on a new bike for the first few years.
- **Engine protect** covers engine and gearbox damage from water or oil loss - useful in flood-prone cities.
- **No-claim bonus (NCB)** rewards a claim-free year with a discount at renewal. Protect it by paying small repairs yourself.
- **Roadside assistance** is cheap and useful if you ride long distances.

The two add-ons that are usually worth it on a new bike are zero-depreciation and engine protect. The one to skip is any cover you already have - do not buy a personal-accident rider twice.

22. The showroom insurance trap

Dealers make money on insurance, and the policy they sell at the counter is often priced above the market. You are not obliged to buy insurance from the dealer to get the bike or the loan, although some will imply that you are.

The third-party premium is the same everywhere, so there is nothing to save there. The own-damage premium is where you can save - by buying a comprehensive policy directly from an insurer or a comparison platform before delivery, and showing the dealer the policy. Ask the dealer for the insurer's name, the IDV and the premium split. If the quote is higher than a direct quote for the same cover, buy it yourself.

What to ask before you sign for insurance

Ask for: the insurer's name and claim-settlement ratio; the IDV; the premium split between third-party and own damage; the list of add-ons and their prices; and the deductible. A dealer who answers all five in writing is being straight with you. One who will not is not.

23. What to do after an accident: the claim process

An accident is stressful. A little preparation means your claim is paid without a fight.

- **Stay safe and get help.** Move to safety, help anyone injured, and call the police if there is an injury or a dispute.
- **Inform your insurer quickly.** Most policies require prompt intimation - call the helpline or use the app the same day.
- **Do not admit fault** at the scene, and do not settle anything in cash without the insurer's knowledge.
- **Document everything.** Photograph the damage, the vehicles and the location, and note the other vehicle's number.
- **Get the vehicle surveyed** before any repair, unless it is a small cashless repair at a network garage.
- **Use a cashless garage** where available, or pay and claim reimbursement with the original bills and the surveyor's report.
- **For theft,** file an FIR immediately and inform the insurer with the FIR copy, both keys and the original documents.
- **Know your NCB.** A claim may reduce your no-claim bonus at renewal - factor that into small claims.

Part 5 - The deal

24. The negotiation script

Two-wheeler showrooms are built to move you from interest to signature quickly. Your job is to slow it down. Here is a sequence that works.

1. **Get the on-road price in writing first.** Before any discount talk, ask for the full breakup - ex-showroom, road tax, registration, insurance, accessories. Take a photo.
2. **Compare at least three dealers** for the same model and variant. Prices for the same bike differ by thousands of rupees between dealers and between cities.
3. **State your own financing.** Get a loan rate from your bank before you visit. Use it as a bargaining point; the dealer's finance offer must beat it to be worth taking.
4. **Separate the bike from the extras.** Agree the vehicle price, then decide on accessories, extended warranty and insurance one by one. Never let them be bundled into one 'package price'.
5. **Ask for the discount in rupees, not percent.** 'What is the final on-road figure?' is the only question that matters.

6 **Be ready to walk.** The single strongest negotiating move is a polite, genuine willingness to buy elsewhere. The festive season rewards patience, not urgency.

Timing helps too. The last week before Dhanteras is the worst time to negotiate - showrooms are full and stock is thin. Late October, or the quieter days after Diwali, are when a salesperson will work harder for your signature.

25. What to sign, what to refuse

Everything at the counter is optional except the vehicle, the road tax, the registration and the mandatory third-party insurance. Treat the rest with suspicion.

Item	Sign?	Why
Vehicle + road tax + registration	Yes	Unavoidable and fixed by the state.
5-year third-party insurance	Yes	Mandatory by law.
Own-damage (comprehensive)	Yes	Buy it, but compare the premium first.
Accessories package	Only if you want them	Usually the dealer's biggest markup.
Extended warranty	Your call	Useful on electric, marginal on petrol.
Zero-down / long-tenure loan	Usually no	Raises total cost. Prefer a shorter tenure.
Handling / logistics fee	No	Ask for the lawful basis, or refuse.

Read the booking form before you pay. Ask what happens to your deposit if the delivery is delayed, if the price changes, or if you cancel. A refundable booking keeps you in control until the final on-road price is agreed and written down.

26. Accessories: worth it and not worth it

Accessories are where a dealer's margin is highest. Buy the ones that add safety or genuine convenience, and skip the ones that only add decoration.

Accessory	Worth it?	Why
BIS-certified helmet	Yes, essential	Legally required and life-saving.
Riding gloves and jacket	Yes	Protection in a fall; useful in Indian traffic.
Mobile holder and USB charger	Yes, if you ride long	Navigation and charging on the go.
Quality body or tank cover	Yes	Protects paint; cheap.
Disc lock or anti-theft device	Yes, in theft-prone areas	Cheap insurance against theft.
Crash guards on a commuter	Your call	Some protection; check it does not affect warranty.
Paint / teflon 'protection'	Usually no	High markup, limited benefit.
Cosmetic stickers and LED kits	No	Adds nothing; can void electrical warranty.

Buy accessories individually, priced one by one, not as a 'festive package'. If you want the lot, ask for the total and then negotiate it down as its own line.

27. Paying and the paperwork you should collect

How you pay matters for your records and your rights. Pay the dealer by a traceable method - NEFT, RTGS, UPI or card - not cash, so you have proof if there is a dispute. Keep the booking receipt, the final invoice and the payment proof together.

When you take delivery, you should walk away with a set of documents. If any is missing, ask for it before you leave the showroom.

- The GST invoice in your name, showing the chassis and engine number.
- Form 20 (registration application), Form 21 (sale certificate) and Form 22 (roadworthiness).
- The insurance policy schedule, showing the third-party and own-damage details.
- The owner's manual and the warranty booklet with the service schedule.
- The delivery receipt confirming accessories and any free items promised.
- The loan agreement and repayment schedule, if you financed the bike.

Part 6 - Delivery, registration and the first month

28. The 22-point delivery inspection

Do not accept delivery on trust. Check the bike yourself, in daylight, before you sign the delivery note. Once you ride out, small defects become your problem.

Check	What to look for
1. Chassis and engine number	Match the numbers on the invoice exactly.
2. Manufacturing date	On the VIN plate. Avoid a bike that has sat for a year.
3. Paint and panels	No scratches, dents, or mismatched paint on any panel.
4. Tyres	Correct size, no cracks, and a recent date code on the sidewall.
5. Wheels and rims	No bends or wobble; spokes tight on spoked wheels.
6. Lights	Headlamp, tail lamp, brake light, indicators and number-plate lamp all work.
7. Horn and switches	Every switch on both handlebar sides functions.
8. Instrument cluster	Odometer shows a realistic delivery reading, not thousands of km.
9. Brakes	Front and rear both bite firmly; brake fluid level correct.
10. Suspension	No leaks, no knocking when you push down on the front and rear.
11. Engine start	Starts cleanly, idles steadily, no unusual noise.
12. Fuel and oil	Fuel present; engine oil at the correct level.
13. Battery and terminals	Terminals tight, battery holds charge.
14. Mirrors	Both fitted, tight and adjustable.
15. HSRP number plate	Fitted, correct number, tamper-proof.
16. Tool kit	Present, complete, and stowed.
17. Accessories promised	Everything you were promised is fitted or handed over.
18. Documents	Invoice, Forms 20/21/22, insurance, warranty booklet all present.
19. Keys	Two keys, both working.

Check	What to look for
20. Test ride	Ride a short loop; check brakes, steering, gearshift or throttle.
21. Charger (EV)	Correct charger supplied and shown working.
22. Warranty start date	Confirm the date the warranty begins.

If anything fails the check, ask for it to be fixed or the bike to be replaced before you accept delivery. A bike is not 'yours' until you sign the delivery note.

29. RTO registration and the HSRP rules

For a new vehicle, the dealer usually handles registration, but you should know what is happening and what it costs.

High Security Registration Plates (HSRP) are mandatory across India under Rule 50 of the Central Motor Vehicles Rules, amended in December 2018. Every new vehicle is fitted with an HSRP by the dealer at registration. If you already own an older two-wheeler registered before 1 April 2019, you must retro-fit an HSRP - states set their own deadline and fee, typically Rs.425 to Rs.745 for a two-wheeler, and fines for non-compliance run up to Rs.5,000 to Rs.10,000. A plate maker's petition is pending in the Supreme Court, but nothing has been stayed, so your state's current rule applies.

An HSRP has a chromium-based Ashoka Chakra hologram, a laser-etched 10-digit identification number, and tamper-proof snap locks. Book only through your state transport department's official portal - not through roadside agents, who charge more and may fit a fake plate.

30. The documents you must keep, and how to carry them

You do not need to carry a bundle of paper any more. Since a 2018 amendment to the Central Motor Vehicles Rules and an MoRTH standard operating procedure, documents held in DigiLocker or the mParivahan app are legally valid and treated at par with originals under the Information Technology Act, 2000.

- **Download both apps** and link them to your Aadhaar. Pull your driving licence and your vehicle's RC into DigiLocker.
- **Check the details are current** - especially insurance validity, which is uploaded from the insurer's database.
- **Keep a PDF backup** on your phone as well, in case the app or network fails at a checkpoint.
- **Renew on time.** A digital document is only valid while it is actually in force.

Tamil Nadu moved to fully digital issuance of driving licences and registration certificates from 15 September 2026, and the trend is national. If a document cannot be shown online because the database lags, the older paper copy is still required - so keep the originals safe at home.

31. Your first 30 days of ownership

A new two-wheeler needs a little care in the first weeks. Get these right and the machine will serve you for years.

- **Follow the running-in advice** in your manual - usually gentle acceleration and varied engine speed for the first 500-1,000 km.
- **Do the first service on time.** The first service is usually free and is required to keep the warranty valid.

- **Check the tyre pressure weekly** and the engine oil level monthly.
- **Keep the bike clean** and get an anti-rust treatment if you live near the coast.
- **Save the service records.** A stamped service history raises your resale value.
- **Get a PUC certificate** where required and renew it on schedule.

32. Helmets and riding gear

Two-wheelers account for about 44.5% of road deaths in India, and a certified helmet is the single most effective protection a rider can have. Indian law requires it, and it also requires that it be a real one.

Since a Quality Control Order that came into force on 1 June 2021, every helmet sold in India must conform to the BIS standard IS 4151:2015 and carry the ISI mark. Helmets sold cheaply at roadsides often carry fake marks and fail on impact. You can check whether a manufacturer is licensed, and report a suspect seller, through the BIS Care app. Riding without a helmet, or with one that does not meet the standard, attracts a fine of Rs.1,000 and can disqualify your licence for three months.

The government has also mandated that two-wheeler manufacturers supply two BIS-certified helmets with every new vehicle - a notification issued in June 2025, with detailed rules still being framed. When it takes effect, the cost of the two helmets will be built into the vehicle price. For now, buy a certified helmet separately and do not compromise on the mark.

Beyond the helmet, a pair of riding gloves and a jacket with padding turn a painful fall into a bruise. Reflective strips or a high-visibility vest help at night, when most two-wheeler accidents happen. None of this is expensive, and all of it is cheaper than a hospital bill.

33. The service schedule for the first two years

Servicing on time keeps the warranty valid and the bike reliable. The exact intervals are in your owner's manual - here is the typical pattern for a new two-wheeler.

Service	Typical timing	What happens
First service	500-1,000 km or 1 month	Usually free labour; oil change; full check.
Second service	3,000-4,000 km	Oil, filter, chain, brakes; often free labour.
Third service	6,000-8,000 km	Oil, air filter, brake and clutch check.
Routine services	Every 3,000-4,000 km or 3 months	Oil and consumables; paid.
Annual	Once a year	Full inspection, insurance renewal, PUC renewal.

The first two or three services are usually free on labour; you pay for consumables like oil and filters. Missing a scheduled service can void your warranty, so keep every bill and get the service book stamped. For an electric two-wheeler the schedule is lighter, but regular dealer servicing is still required to keep the battery warranty intact.

Part 7 - Buying electric

34. The EV buying checklist

An electric two-wheeler is a different purchase from a petrol one. The battery is the single most expensive part and the thing most likely to go wrong. Buy on these points, in this order.

- **Certified safety.** The model must comply with AIS-156 (as amended), which mandates a microprocessor-based battery management system, thermal-propagation protection, an audio-visual warning before a thermal event, and IPX7 water protection for the pack. Ask for the certificate.
- **Battery warranty - read the fine print.** Look at the years, the kilometre cap, the State-of-Health threshold, and what voids it.
- **State of Health guarantee.** Most brands replace the pack if its usable capacity falls below 70% within the warranty period. Confirm your model has this.
- **Home charging.** Confirm the charger type and whether you can charge from a normal 15-amp socket.
- **Service network.** Check the nearest authorised service centre. Battery faults need a dealer, not a local mechanic.
- **Subsidy eligibility.** Confirm the model qualifies for the PM E-DRIVE incentive and that the dealer passes it on in the price.
- **Real range, not claimed range.** Real-world range is usually 20-30% lower than the claimed IDC figure.

One important 2026 update: the PM E-DRIVE incentive for electric two-wheelers was extended to 31 March 2028. An eligible e-two-wheeler gets Rs.2,500 per kWh, capped at Rs.5,000, provided its ex-factory price is Rs.1.5 lakh or less. Confirm the discount appears on your invoice - the dealer claims it and passes it on.

35. EV battery warranties compared

Warranties vary a lot between brands. A longer warranty with a State-of-Health guarantee is worth real money on a used sale. Terms below are as publicly stated by the brands in 2026 - verify at the dealer.

Brand / model	Standard battery warranty	State-of-Health guarantee
Ather (450 / Rizta)	3 yr / 30,000 km (5 yr with Pro Pack)	70%, with extended plans
TVS iQube	3 yr / 30,000-50,000 km by variant	Not stated as a claim threshold
Bajaj Chetak	3 yr / 50,000 km	Manufacturer terms
Hero Vida	5 yr / 50,000 km	70% under extended plan
Ola Electric S1	3 yr / 50,000 km (up to 8 yr options)	70%, certified after 10,000 km
Ampere (LFP range)	3-5 yr / 30,000-75,000 km	Capacity threshold in terms

What voids a battery warranty, almost universally: using a non-approved charger, water ingress beyond the tested rating, leaving the pack fully discharged for long periods, tampering with the battery or BMS, and skipping scheduled services. Use the supplied charger, charge regularly, and service on time.

Part 8 - Life after you buy

36. Ownership cost and resale

The purchase price is the beginning, not the end. Budget for the running costs, and buy with resale in mind.

A petrol commuter costs roughly Rs.1.5-2.5 per kilometre in fuel, plus servicing every few months and insurance each year. An electric scooter costs a fraction per kilometre but has a battery that will

eventually need attention - which is why the warranty matters. Either way, keep the service records and the bike clean: a well-maintained two-wheeler with a stamped service history sells for noticeably more, and popular commuter models hold value best.

When you sell, the buyer will check the RC, the insurance, the service history and the HSRP. Transfer the RC in the buyer's name through the RTO - do not hand over the bike with the RC still in your name, because you stay legally liable for challans and accidents until the transfer is recorded.

37. The 15-year rule: fitness test or scrap

A private two-wheeler's first registration is valid for 15 years. After that you have two legal paths, under the Vehicle Scrappage Policy and the Central Motor Vehicles Rules.

- **Renew.** Take the bike to an Automated Testing Station for a fitness test. If it passes, the registration is renewed, typically for five more years. You pay a re-registration fee and any green tax your state applies.
- **Scrap.** If it fails, or you choose to, scrap it at a Registered Vehicle Scrapping Facility. You get the scrap value plus a Certificate of Deposit, which can give a discount on a new vehicle and a road-tax rebate of up to 25% in most states.

Delhi-NCR is stricter - petrol two-wheelers are not allowed beyond 15 years there, with no renewal. Elsewhere, a well-maintained bike that passes fitness can stay on the road. If you keep a two-wheeler past 15 years, plan for the fitness test, the green tax and higher renewal costs.

38. Traffic fines every rider should know

The Motor Vehicles (Amendment) Act, 2019 raised penalties sharply. Most of the common two-wheeler offences now cost a thousand rupees or more, and some suspend your licence. States can raise these further under Section 210A, so treat the figures below as the central-act minimums.

Offence	Fine	Licence impact
Riding without a helmet	Rs.1,000	Disqualified for 3 months
Helmet not BIS-certified or strap not tied	Rs.1,000	Disqualification applies
Driving without a licence	Rs.5,000	Also liable to imprisonment
Driving without insurance	Rs.2,000 (first offence)	Rs.4,000 on a repeat
Overloading a two-wheeler	Rs.2,000	Disqualified for 3 months
Dangerous driving	Up to Rs.5,000	Possible imprisonment
Drunk driving	Rs.10,000	Imprisonment possible
Over-speeding	Rs.1,000 to Rs.2,000	Second offence can impound the licence
General offence	Rs.500	First offence

Pay any e-challan through the official Parivahan portal or your state's traffic police site, and check that the vehicle number and offence are correct before you pay. An unpaid challan can block a registration transfer or an insurance claim later, so clear them promptly.

Part 9 - Reference and tools

39. The ten questions to ask the dealer

Take this list into every showroom. A dealer who answers all ten in writing is worth buying from. One who dodges is not.

1. What is the full on-road price, itemised - ex-showroom, road tax, registration, insurance and any other charge?
2. What is the exact variant and colour, and is it in stock today?
3. What is the current road tax slab for my state on this vehicle?
4. What is the insurance premium split between third-party and own damage, and what is the IDV?
5. What is the rate and tenure of the finance you are offering, and what is the total interest?
6. What is the processing fee, and is it waived this quarter?
7. What is the delivery timeline, and will I get a Temporary Registration certificate if it is delayed?
8. What exactly is included in the 'accessories package', priced individually?
9. What does the extended warranty cover, and what does it exclude?
10. What is the final, all-in figure I will pay, in writing?

40. Reading your invoice line by line

The invoice is your proof of what you bought and paid for. Read it before you sign, and match every line to what you agreed.

Line on the invoice	What it should show	Red flag
Ex-showroom price	The listed price for your variant	Higher than the manufacturer's listed price
Road tax	Your state's slab on this vehicle	A round 'estimated' figure with no basis
Registration / HSRP	RTO fee plus plate cost	A separate 'registration service fee'
Insurance	Insurer, IDV, TP and OD split	One lump figure with no breakup
Accessories	Each item priced separately	A single 'package' figure
Handling / logistics	Should be absent or justified	An undisclosed lump-sum add-on
Total	Single figure with full breakup	Compulsory and voluntary charges not separated

Under the Consumer Protection (General) Rules, 2020, the invoice must state the total price in a single figure with a breakup of all compulsory and voluntary charges. If it does not, ask for it to be rewritten. If a charge has no statutory basis, ask for it to be removed - and if the dealer refuses, that is a matter for your RTO.

41. Cash, finance or exchange: three ways to pay

There is no single best way to pay. It depends on your cash position and what the money could otherwise earn.

Way to pay	Good when	Watch out for
Cash / full payment	You have the funds and no better use for them	Ties up money; negotiate a discount for paying outright
Loan	You need the bike now and can service the EMI	Total interest, processing fee, zero-down traps
Exchange	You have an old two-wheeler to sell	A low dealer valuation; get an independent quote first

A common mistake is exchanging and financing at the same time without checking either number. Price the old bike with an independent buyer, then compare it with the dealer's exchange offer, and negotiate the new bike's price separately. Bundling the two hides which side is short-changing you.

42. What the warranty covers - and what it does not

A warranty is a promise about manufacturing defects, not a service contract. Knowing the difference stops arguments later.

- **Covered:** manufacturing defects in the engine, frame, electricals and, on an EV, the battery and motor, within the stated period or kilometre cap.
- **Not covered:** wear-and-tear parts - tyres, brake pads, clutch plates, bulbs, chains and sprockets.
- **Not covered:** damage from an accident, misuse, water ingress, or unauthorised repairs and non-genuine parts.
- **Voided by:** missing scheduled services, fitting non-approved electrical accessories, or tampering with the engine or battery.
- **Keep it valid:** service on time at an authorised centre and keep every bill and the stamped service book.

On an electric two-wheeler, read the battery warranty separately - the years, the kilometre cap, the State-of-Health threshold and the conditions that void it are the most important terms in the whole purchase.

43. Fuel-saving and care habits that pay for themselves

A well-kept two-wheeler costs less to run and sells for more. These habits are free.

- **Keep tyre pressure correct.** Under-inflated tyres cut mileage and wear out faster.
- **Ride at a steady speed.** Hard acceleration and braking burn fuel; a smooth throttle saves it.
- **Avoid long idling.** Switch off at signals longer than a minute.
- **Service on schedule.** A clean air filter and fresh oil keep mileage up.
- **Do not overload.** Carrying more than the manual allows hurts mileage and safety.
- **Wash and lube.** Clean the chain and lubricate it regularly; wash off road salt in winter.
- **Park under cover.** Sun and rain age paint, plastic and electricals.

44. Anti-theft and everyday safety

Two-wheelers are the most stolen vehicles in India. A few cheap habits protect your machine and you.

- **Park in well-lit, busy places** and use a disc lock or a quality chain in addition to the steering lock.
- **Record your chassis and engine numbers** and keep a photo of the RC on your phone.

- **Never leave the keys or documents in the vehicle.**
- **Use a GPS tracker** on a new or expensive bike; recovery rates rise sharply with one.
- **Ride with your headlight on** in the day if your model allows - it makes you visible.
- **Do not ride with earphones in,** and never use the phone while riding.
- **If it is stolen,** file an FIR at once and inform your insurer with the FIR copy and both keys.

45. RTO forms, explained

The RTO runs on forms. You do not need to fill them yourself at a dealer, but knowing which is which helps you check your paperwork.

Form	What it is for
Form 20	Application for registration of a new vehicle
Form 21	Sale certificate issued by the dealer
Form 22	Certificate of roadworthiness of the vehicle
Form 25	Application for renewal of a fitness certificate
Form 29 and 30	Notice and report of transfer of ownership when you sell
Form 34 and 35	Entry and removal of hypothecation when you take or clear a loan

When you sell, the transfer is only complete when the RTO records it. Until then, challans and liabilities remain yours. Always use Forms 29 and 30 through the RTO, and keep a copy of the transfer confirmation.

46. Glossary of the words dealers use

Term	What it means
Ex-showroom price	The price of the vehicle including GST, before road tax and registration
On-road price	What you actually pay: ex-showroom plus road tax, registration and insurance
HSRP	High Security Registration Plate - the tamper-proof number plate, mandatory
Third-party cover	Insurance that pays for damage you cause to others; mandatory for 5 years
Own-damage (OD)	Cover for your own vehicle; renewed annually
IDV	Insured Declared Value - the amount your bike is insured for
NCB	No-Claim Bonus - a discount at renewal for a claim-free year
Hypothecation	The lender's charge on the vehicle until the loan is repaid
Temporary Registration	A short-term registration (Form 43 route) used before permanent registration
Vahan / Sarathi	The central vehicle and driving-licence databases
PUC	Pollution Under Control certificate
AIS-156	The safety standard for electric two-wheeler batteries and systems
SoH	State of Health - a battery's usable capacity as a percentage of new
TCS	Tax collected at source; applies to vehicles above Rs.10 lakh, so not to two-wheelers

47. Your key-numbers quick card

The figures from this playbook, on one page. Verify before you pay.

Item	Figure (as verified, mid-October 2026)
GST on two-wheelers up to 350cc	18% (down from 28%, effective 22 Sep 2025)
GST on two-wheelers above 350cc	40%
GST on electric two-wheelers	5%
PM E-DRIVE e-2W incentive	Rs.2,500/kWh, capped at Rs.5,000; runs to 31 March 2028
RBI repo rate	5.50% (raised 7 October 2026)
Two-wheeler loan rates	About 8.5% (PSU banks) to 24% (NBFCs)
5-year third-party premium (75-150cc)	Rs.3,851
5-year third-party premium (150-350cc)	Rs.7,365
Road tax range (petrol 2W)	About 2% (Delhi slabs) to 18% (Karnataka)
HSRP retro-fit fee (2W)	About Rs.425 to Rs.745, state-set
Helmet fine	Rs.1,000 and 3-month licence disqualification
Festive discount (typical)	Rs.2,000 to Rs.5,000

Part 10 - Going deeper

48. Choosing the variant: brakes, wheels and tyres

Two bikes with the same engine can differ sharply in safety and convenience by variant. These are the choices that matter.

Feature	What the rule is now	What to choose
Brakes (below 125cc)	Combined braking system (CBS) mandatory since 2019	A front disc brake is worth the extra; it stops better than a drum
Brakes (above 125cc)	Anti-lock braking system (ABS) mandatory	ABS prevents wheel lock-up and skidding - take it
ABS for all bikes	Proposed from January 2026, not notified as of October 2026	Ask the dealer whether your model already has it
Wheels	Steel or alloy	Alloy wheels allow tubeless tyres and resist rust
Tyres	Tube or tubeless	Tubeless tyres deflate slowly on a puncture - safer and easier
Console and lights	Analogue or digital; halogen or LED	LED lights and a digital console are worth it on a daily rider

The government has proposed making ABS mandatory on all two-wheelers from January 2026, but the rule had not been formally notified as of October 2026 after industry pushback on cost and supply. Until it is, CBS remains the requirement below 125cc. If safety matters to you and the budget allows, choose a variant with ABS and a front disc regardless of the engine size.

49. What E20 fuel means for your mileage

Since April 2025, the petrol sold across India has contained 20% ethanol - E20. It is worth knowing what that does to your running costs.

The government completed the nationwide E20 rollout in April 2025, five years ahead of the original target, and from 1 April 2026 the blended petrol must meet a minimum octane rating (RON 95). More than 20 crore two-wheelers have been running on it, and ARAI's testing found no durability problems in two-wheelers. Manufacturers continue to honour warranties on vehicles using E20.

The one practical effect is mileage. ARAI found fuel consumption rises by about 2% to 6% on E20 compared with the older E10 blend. So if you are comparing your new bike's real-world economy against an old figure from 2023, expect it to be a little lower - and budget for it. Keep the fuel system serviced and the bike should run normally.

50. A worked case study: buying a scooter in Bengaluru

Numbers make the method concrete. Here is an illustrative walk-through for a first-time buyer in Bengaluru. The figures are examples, not quotes.

Step	The buyer's decision
Budget	Take-home pay Rs.40,000. Cap the scooter at 12% = about Rs.4,800 a month.
Shortlist	A 110cc petrol scooter and an electric scooter from an established brand.
On-road price	Petrol: Rs.90,000 ex-showroom + about Rs.10,000 road tax (Karnataka) + about Rs.1,000 registration + about Rs.8,000 insurance = about Rs.1,09,000.
Loan	Rs.80,000 borrowed over 36 months at 11% = about Rs.2,620 a month EMI.
Running cost	800 km a month at 50 kmpl = about Rs.1,650 of petrol.
Monthly total	About Rs.4,270 - within the Rs.4,800 cap.
Negotiation	Three dealers quoted; the discount ranged Rs.2,000-4,500. The buyer booked in late October and took delivery on Dhanteras.
Delivery	The 22-point check found a scratched panel; the dealer replaced it before delivery.

Notice what decided the outcome: not the sticker price, but the monthly total and the willingness to compare dealers and check the bike. The same method works for a motorcycle or an electric scooter - only the numbers change.

51. If something goes wrong: the complaint ladder

Most problems are small and fixed at the dealership. When they are not, escalate in this order and keep every record.

- **Step 1 - the service manager.** Report the fault in writing, keep the job card, and set a deadline for a fix.
- **Step 2 - the dealer principal.** If the manager does not resolve it, write to the owner of the dealership with the history.
- **Step 3 - the manufacturer.** Every brand has a toll-free customer-care line. Raise a complaint and get a complaint number.
- **Step 4 - the RTO.** For registration, HSRP or an unlawful charge, complain to your Regional Transport Office.

- **Step 5 - the consumer commission.** Under the Consumer Protection Act, 2019, you can file on the e-Daakhil portal; the District Commission handles claims up to Rs.50 lakh.
- **For insurance,** use the insurer's grievance officer first, then IRDAI's grievance system or the Insurance Ombudsman.

The single most useful habit is documentation: a written complaint with a date, a job card, and receipts turn a dispute you might lose into one you usually win.

52. Your insurance renewal calendar

The five-year third-party policy looks after itself. The part that catches people out is the annual own-damage renewal.

- **Year 0:** you pay five years of third-party plus one year of own damage at purchase.
- **Every year after:** renew the own-damage cover before it expires - or the bike is uninsured for its own damage, and a break can cost you your no-claim bonus.
- **Do not let the whole policy lapse.** Driving without insurance attracts a fine of Rs.2,000 on the first offence and Rs.4,000 on a repeat.
- **Compare before you renew.** The own-damage premium is competitive; a renewal quote from your existing insurer is not automatically the best.
- **Protect your NCB.** Pay small repairs yourself to keep a claim-free record, which lowers the next premium.

Put the renewal date in your phone calendar a fortnight ahead. It is the cheapest piece of insurance discipline there is.

53. A model comparison worksheet

Fill this in for your three shortlisted models before you decide. Score each out of five on the things that matter to you, and let the total decide.

Compare	Model A	Model B	Model C
On-road price			
Real-world mileage / range			
Brakes (CBS / ABS / disc)			
Warranty length			
Nearest service centre (km)			
Monthly cost (EMI + fuel)			
Comfort and seat height			
Your score (out of 5)			

A model that wins on price but loses on service distance or warranty is rarely the right choice. The worksheet makes that trade-off visible before you sign.

Part 11 - Getting the details right

54. How to read a two-wheeler spec sheet

Showroom brochures are full of numbers that sound impressive and mean little. These are the ones that actually matter for a daily rider.

Spec	What it means	What matters for you
Engine capacity (cc)	The size of the engine	Bigger is not always better; match it to your daily distance
Max power (PS)	Peak output at high revs	Matters on the highway, little in city traffic
Max torque (Nm)	Pulling power at low revs	This is what you feel off the line - important for a pillion
Kerb weight (kg)	The bike's weight with fuel	Lighter is easier to handle in traffic and to park
Seat height (mm)	Height of the seat	Check you can put both feet down comfortably
Ground clearance (mm)	Gap under the bike	More clearance helps on broken roads and speed breakers
Fuel tank (litres)	How much fuel it holds	Range = tank x real mileage, not claimed mileage
Claimed mileage	Test-cycle figure	Real-world is usually 10-20% lower, and E20 trims it further
Battery (kWh), EVs	Energy stored	More kWh means more range but more cost and weight

Ignore peak power if you ride in the city. Look at torque, weight and seat height. For an electric scooter, look at the real-world range and the battery warranty, not the claimed IDC figure.

55. Comfort on Indian roads: what actually matters

A bike you can ride for an hour without aching beats one with a better spec sheet. Comfort comes from a few things you can check on a test ride.

- **Seat.** A wide, well-padded seat with a gentle shape matters more than a fancy console. Sit on it for ten minutes in the showroom.
- **Suspension.** On rough roads, a bike that soaks up bumps protects your back. Test-ride over a broken patch.
- **Riding posture.** A commuter with an upright stance is comfortable in traffic; a sporty stance is not for everyone.
- **Pillion comfort.** If you carry someone daily, check the pillion seat, footrests and grab rail.
- **Vibration.** Some single-cylinder engines buzz at highway speed. Notice it on the test ride.
- **Wind and weather.** A small windscreen helps on the highway; not needed for pure city use.

A test ride is not a formality. Ride the exact variant you plan to buy, over the kind of roads you actually use, before you commit.

56. Green flags and red flags at a dealership

You can learn a lot about a dealer before you spend a rupee. Watch for these.

Green flags	Red flags
Puts the full on-road price in writing, unprompted	Refuses to give a written breakup
Quotes the road tax from the official slab	Gives a round 'estimated' tax figure
Lets you buy insurance elsewhere	Insists you must buy their insurance
Prices accessories individually	Bundles a vague 'accessory package'
Explains the warranty terms clearly	Dodges questions about what voids the warranty
Gives a realistic delivery date in writing	Promises delivery 'within a day or two' vaguely
Has a service centre you can visit	Has no local service network

A dealer who is straight with you on the small things will usually be straight on the big ones. One who hides the on-road breakup is telling you how the after-sales relationship will go.

57. Your six-week festive planner

Work backwards from Diwali on 8 November. This is the schedule that gets you the best price without the Dhanteras panic.

Week	Dates	What to do
Week 1	13-19 October	Set your budget, shortlist models, and test-ride each one.
Week 2	20-26 October	Collect written on-road quotes from three dealers; get a bank loan rate.
Week 3	27 October-2 November	Negotiate, compare insurance quotes, agree the final figure in writing.
Week 4	3-5 November	Book with a refundable deposit; confirm stock and the delivery date.
Dhanteras / Diwali	6-8 November	Take delivery on your muhurat; do the 22-point check first.
After	9-30 November	Do the first service; register the HSRP and pull documents into DigiLocker.

If you are reading this after early November, do not rush to catch the muhurat. The quieter weeks after Diwali often give the best negotiation, and the later muhurat dates in late November are still auspicious.

58. Ten more questions to ask about your loan

If you are financing, these questions decide what the bike really costs you.

1. What is the interest rate - fixed or floating - and what is the effective annual rate?
2. What is the total interest I will pay over the full tenure?
3. What is the processing fee, and is it waived this quarter?
4. Is there a prepayment or foreclosure penalty if I repay early?
5. What is the maximum loan-to-value you will give, and how much down payment do I need?
6. Are there any other charges - documentation, insurance bundling, or a mandatory accessory pack?
7. What happens if I miss an EMI - what is the late fee and does it affect my credit score?
8. Is the rate fixed for the whole tenure or reset periodically?
9. Can I add a co-applicant to get a better rate?
10. Will the loan be closed and the hypothecation removed promptly when I repay?

59. Choosing for a family, not just yourself

If the two-wheeler is for the household, not just you, the priorities change.

- **Who will ride it?** If several family members will, an automatic scooter is easier than a geared bike.
- **How many people at once?** Regular pillion use points to a wider seat and stronger low-end torque, not a sporty machine.
- **Where will it be parked?** A lighter vehicle is easier to move in a tight compound or a crowded street.
- **Who will service it?** A model with a wide service network and cheap spares suits a family better than a niche brand.
- **What is the fuel budget?** A high-mileage commuter or an electric scooter from a trusted brand keeps the monthly cost down.

A family two-wheeler is judged by how little trouble it causes over five years, not by how it looks in the showroom. Reliability, service access and running cost come first.

60. The one-page festive buying checklist

Print this. Tick it off in order.

#	Do this	Done
1	Work out your total monthly budget (EMI + fuel + insurance + servicing)	
2	Decide petrol or electric using your monthly kilometres and charging access	
3	Shortlist three models you can service nearby	
4	Get the full on-road price breakup in writing from three dealers	
5	Get a loan rate from your own bank before you visit any showroom	
6	Compare the own-damage insurance premium with a direct quote	
7	Separate the vehicle price from accessories, warranty and insurance	
8	Refuse any handling, logistics or documentation fee with no lawful basis	
9	Confirm the discount in rupees, on the final on-road figure	
10	Check the road tax rate for your state's current slab	
11	Book in late October when stock and choice are best	
12	Keep the booking refundable until the price is agreed	
13	Do the 22-point delivery inspection in daylight	
14	Collect the invoice, Forms 20/21/22, insurance and warranty booklet	
15	Confirm HSRP is fitted and the RC is registered in your name	
16	Download DigiLocker and mParivahan and pull your RC and DL	
17	Buy a BIS-certified helmet before you ride away	
18	Do the first service on time to keep the warranty valid	

61. Frequently asked questions

Is it worth waiting for Dhanteras?

Dhanteras (6 November 2026) is the biggest buying day, but it is also the most crowded, with the fastest-selling colours gone and the least room to negotiate. Book in late October when stock is full and you can compare dealers calmly, and time delivery to your muhurat. You get the auspicious day and the better deal.

Has the electric two-wheeler subsidy really ended?

No. Many guides say the PM E-DRIVE e-two-wheeler subsidy ended on 31 July 2026, but a notification dated 10 August 2026 extended it to 31 March 2028, at Rs.2,500 per kWh capped at Rs.5,000 per vehicle. Confirm your model's eligibility with the dealer.

Can I refuse the dealer's insurance?

You must have the mandatory five-year third-party cover, but you are not obliged to buy it from the dealer. The third-party premium is fixed by IRDAI and identical everywhere; the own-damage premium is where you can save by buying a comprehensive policy directly.

Is a five-year insurance policy compulsory?

Yes, for every new two-wheeler. It comes from a Supreme Court order and an IRDAI circular effective 1 September 2018. It is third-party cover only; own-damage is renewed annually.

Is the GST cut already in the price?

Yes. The 18% rate for two-wheelers up to 350cc took effect on 22 September 2025 and is reflected in current ex-showroom prices. If a dealer shows a discount against an old 2024 price, that is the tax cut, not a festive offer.

Will loan rates rise this festive season?

The RBI raised the repo rate to 5.50% on 7 October 2026 and said cuts are off the table for now, so rates are more likely to rise than fall. Lock in your rate and tenure rather than waiting.

Do I need to carry paper documents?

No. Documents in DigiLocker or the mParivahan app are legally valid under the IT Act, 2000. Keep the physical originals safe at home and a PDF backup on your phone.

How much discount is realistic?

Typically Rs.2,000 to Rs.5,000 in cash on popular models, sometimes with insurance or accessories bundled. Treat it as a tie-breaker between two models you already like, not a reason to buy.

Can I be charged a handling fee?

Charges with no statutory basis should be refused. Invoices must itemise compulsory and voluntary charges under the Consumer Protection (General) Rules, 2020, and states such as Telangana have ordered refunds of unauthorised handling, logistics and documentation fees.

Is an electric scooter cheaper to run?

Usually yes, if you charge at home and ride enough. An electric scooter costs a fraction per kilometre versus petrol. But if you ride under about 500 km a month or cannot charge at home, petrol is the better buy.

Should I buy new or used?

Buy used if your budget is tight or you will not keep the bike long, but check the RC, loan status, insurance, service history and HSRP, and get an RC transfer. Buy new for the warranty, the EV subsidy and a zero-kilometre machine.

What is the biggest mistake buyers make?

Shopping by ex-showroom price instead of total monthly cost, and accepting the dealer's bundled 'package price' without separating the vehicle, insurance and accessories. Get the on-road breakup in writing and compare it across dealers.

62. Sources and how to verify

Every fact in this playbook was checked against official or first-party sources as of mid-October 2026. Where a figure can change, the source tells you where to confirm it yourself before you buy.

- **Tax rates:** GST Council / CBIC notifications on the September 2025 rate reform.
- **EV subsidy:** Ministry of Heavy Industries PM E-DRIVE scheme notifications (29 September 2024; 27 March 2026; 10 August 2026).
- **Interest rates:** RBI Monetary Policy Statement, October 2026; individual bank rate cards (SBI, Bank of India, Canara Bank).
- **Insurance:** IRDAI circulars on long-term motor third-party cover and the annual third-party premium rate card.
- **Registration and HSRP:** Central Motor Vehicles Rules, 1989 (Rule 50 and Rule 139) and state transport department notices.
- **Dealer charges:** Consumer Protection (General) Rules, 2020; state transport department orders.
- **Road tax:** State transport department notifications and the Vahan portal (vahan.parivahan.gov.in).
- **Market data:** Vahan registration data, Ministry of Road Transport and Highways.
- **Helmets:** BIS Quality Control Order for helmets and the Department of Consumer Affairs.
- **Fines:** Motor Vehicles (Amendment) Act, 2019 and state traffic police challan schedules.
- **Battery safety:** AIS-156 and BIS standards for electric vehicle batteries.

This document is an independent buying guide. It is not affiliated with any manufacturer, dealer or insurer, and it is not financial advice. Prices, taxes and scheme rules change; verify the current figures with your dealer, your bank and your state transport department before you pay.